

1. *The Conscious Mind* by Chalmers (1996)

1.1. Introduction

1.1.1. Taking Consciousness Seriously

About consciousness as an “illusion”:

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I have little idea what this could even mean. It seems to me that we are surer of the existence of conscious experience than we are of anything else in the world.

Doesn't an illusion require that there are things that are real, and things that just appear to be real, i.e., those illusions.

Chalmers starts with three constraints

- a. Take consciousness seriously
- b. Take science seriously
- c. Accept consciousness as natural phenomenon

Chalmers considers two problems or perhaps kinds of problems: The easy problems of consciousness that build upon the assumption that it can be understood by analysing cognition and behaviours. The hard problem is that those problems are insufficient for understanding the consciousness. These two sets of problems are on the opposite ends of a “Great Divide”. If you hold that the answer to an easy problem explains it all, you will get one theory. If you base your theory on the existence of hard problems it will be very different.

I argue that reductive explanations of consciousness impossible and I even argue for a form of dualism. But this is just a part of the scientific process. Certain sorts of explanation turn out to not work, so we need to embrace other sorts of explanation instead. Everything I say here is compatible with the results of contemporary science; our picture of the natural world is broadened, not overturned.

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1.2. Foundations

1.2.1. Two Concepts of Mind

What is consciousness?

Chalmers doesn't use any definition of his own. His definition is formulated through Nagel (1974)

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We can say that a being is conscious if there is *something it is like* to be that being.

References

Chalmers, David J., *The Conscious Mind: In Search of a Fundamental Theory*, Oxford University Press, New York (1996).

Nagel, Thomas, “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” *The Philosophical Review* **83**, pp. 435-450 (1974). <https://doi.org/10.2307/2183914>.